By facilitating the outbreak of serious Indo-Pakistani crises in the past, then, nuclear weapons have inspired strategic developments that will make the outbreak and rapid escalation of regional crises more likely in the future. Thus nuclear weapons proliferation not only destabilized South Asia in the first decade since the 1998 tests but is also likely to increase dangers on the subcontinent in the years to come.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter, we discuss nuclear weapons' impact on the current South Asian security environment and speculate as to their likely effects on the region's future. We agree that the Indo-Pakistani security relationship has improved in recent years, but we disagree as to why this occurred. Ganguly argues that recent improvement resulted, to a large degree, from the deterrent effects of nuclear weapons; leaders in both New Delhi and Islamabad realized that in a nuclear environment, continued conflict is prohibitively dangerous; therefore they have decided to pursue peaceful relations. Ganguly expects this pacifying effect to continue in the future. Kapur believes that nuclear weapons have had little to do with current improvements, which he attributes to economic, diplomatic, and nonnuclear strategic factors. And he argues that nuclear weapons, by facilitating past Indo-Pakistani conflict, could destabilize the region in coming years.

ooooo

In chapter 6, we shift our focus away from our competing arguments, instead discussing three issues upon which we agree. First, we argue that our differing approaches to nuclear proliferation actually share important common ground and diverge mainly on which aspect of nuclearized crisis behavior one thinks is most important. To a significant degree, the difference between our arguments is one of emphasis on either the stable outcomes of past South Asian militarized disputes or the dangerous processes by which these